EVERETT HOUSING AUTHORITY

# Welcome to the Family Self-Sufficiency Program Introduction

# Agenda

1. Who is Everett Housing Authority?
2. What is FSS?
3. How the FSS Savings Account Works
4. What is Financial Coaching?
5. Graduation Requirements
6. Enrollment

# Who is Everett Housing Authority?

EVERETT
HOUSING AUTHORITY

- Everett Housing Authority (EHA) has been committed to serving citizens of Everett, Washington and their housing needs since 1942. As a consistent and reliable source for affordable housing. We have focused our efforts on creating housing options for a variety of income levels in the Greater Everett Area.

# Our Mission

- The Everett Housing Authority creates affordable housing, fosters healthy communities where households thrive, and replaces systemic racism with equity for all.

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# What is FSS?

# FSS BASICS

- HUD Program which began over 25 years ago
- FSS has been consistent at EHA for 10+ years
- One coordinator for a total caseload of 50
- FSS is a 5-year participation program
- Main purpose: decrease reliance on subsidies while increasing self-sufficiency through education, training, job retention, and financial literacy

# It starts with your hopes and dreams…

The Family Self-Sufficiency (FSS) Program is a voluntary program for families who live in federally subsidized housing.

It is designed to help participants reach their goals, build financial stability, and get ahead!

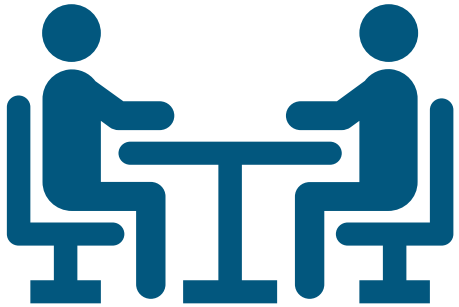
# We believe in our participants and their ability to achieve their hopes and dreams!

# Some of the goals that we see are:

- ☐ Improve my credit
- ☐ Pay off debt
- ☐ Buy a home
- ☐ Pursue a career that I love
- ☐ Buy a car
- ☐ Start a business
- ☐ Establish an emergency fund
- ☐ Save for retirement
- ☐ Save for my child's education
- ☐ Go back to school
- ☐ _____ (other goal)

# How it works:

**Financial Coaching**



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**Goal Completion**

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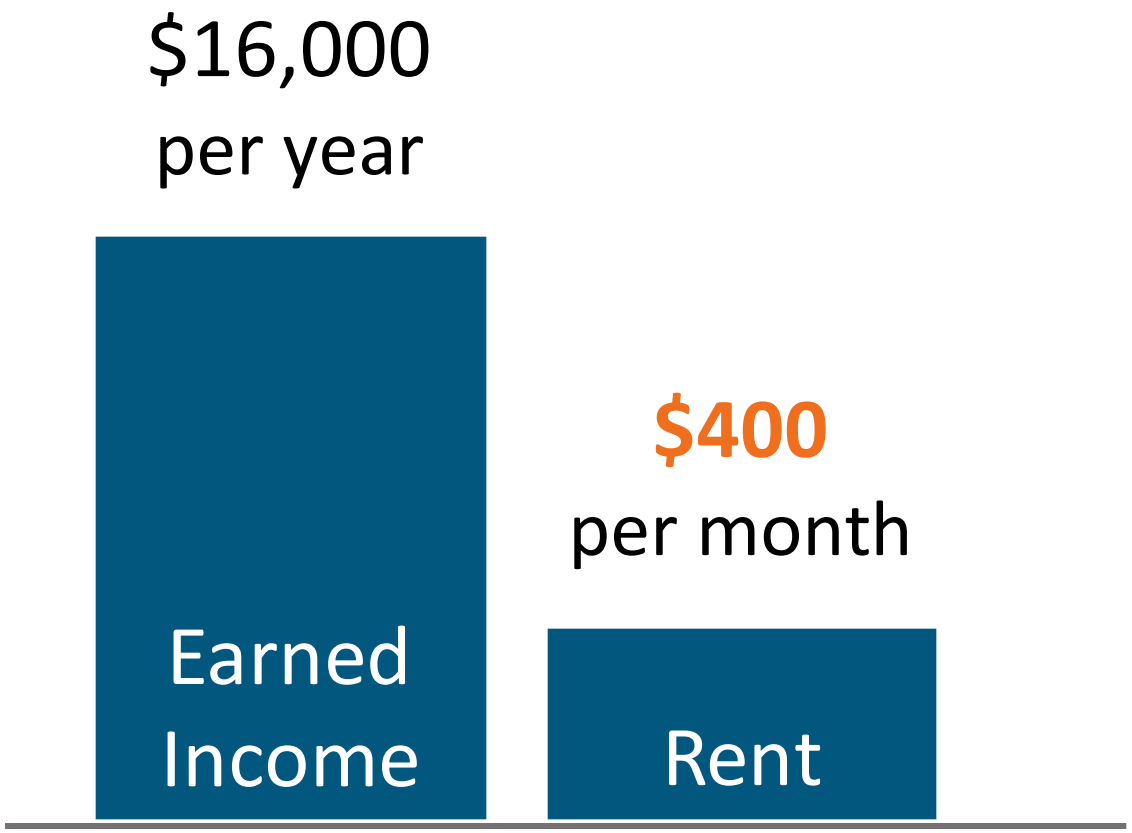
**FSS Savings Account and Financial Empowerment**

The program typically lasts at least 5 years, but participants can graduate earlier if they meet the requirements sooner.

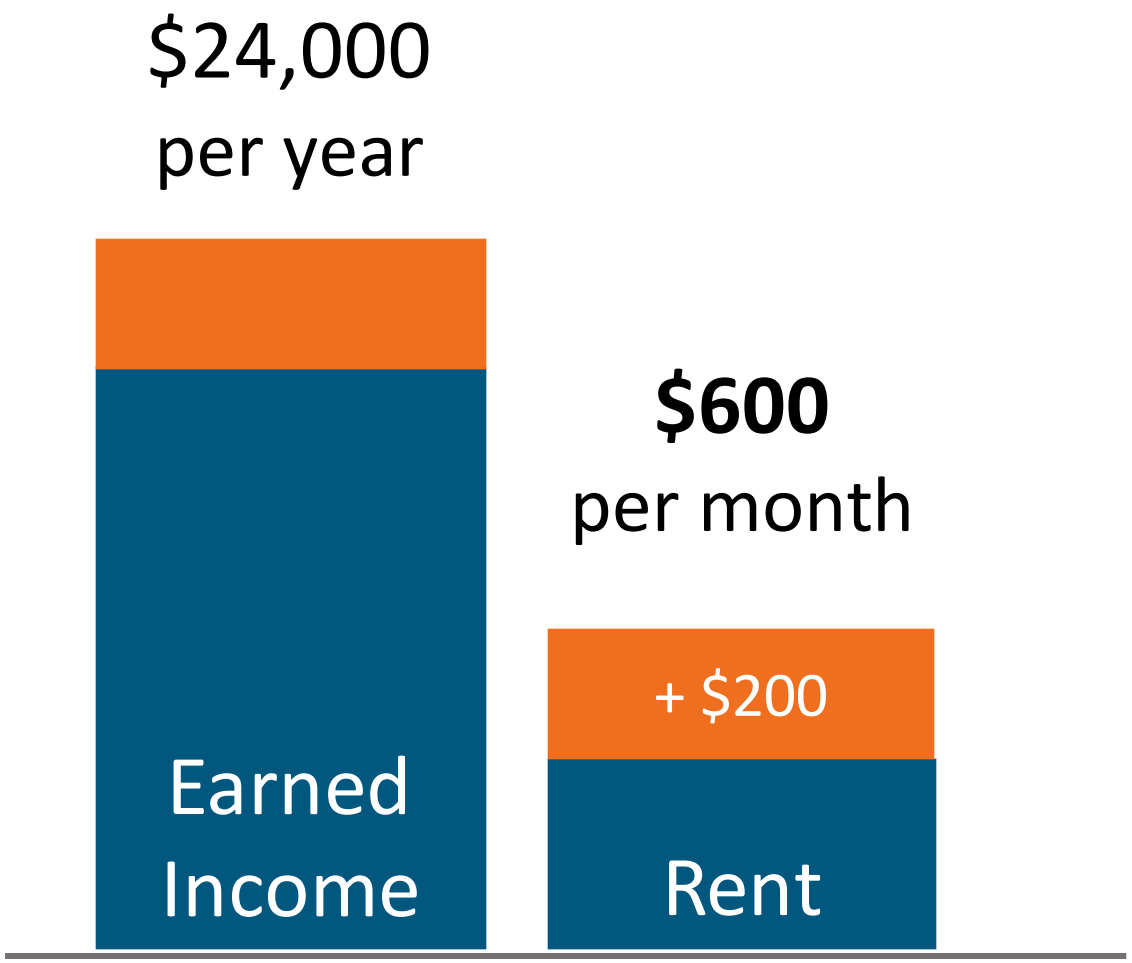
# How the Savings Account Works

*Here is an Example*

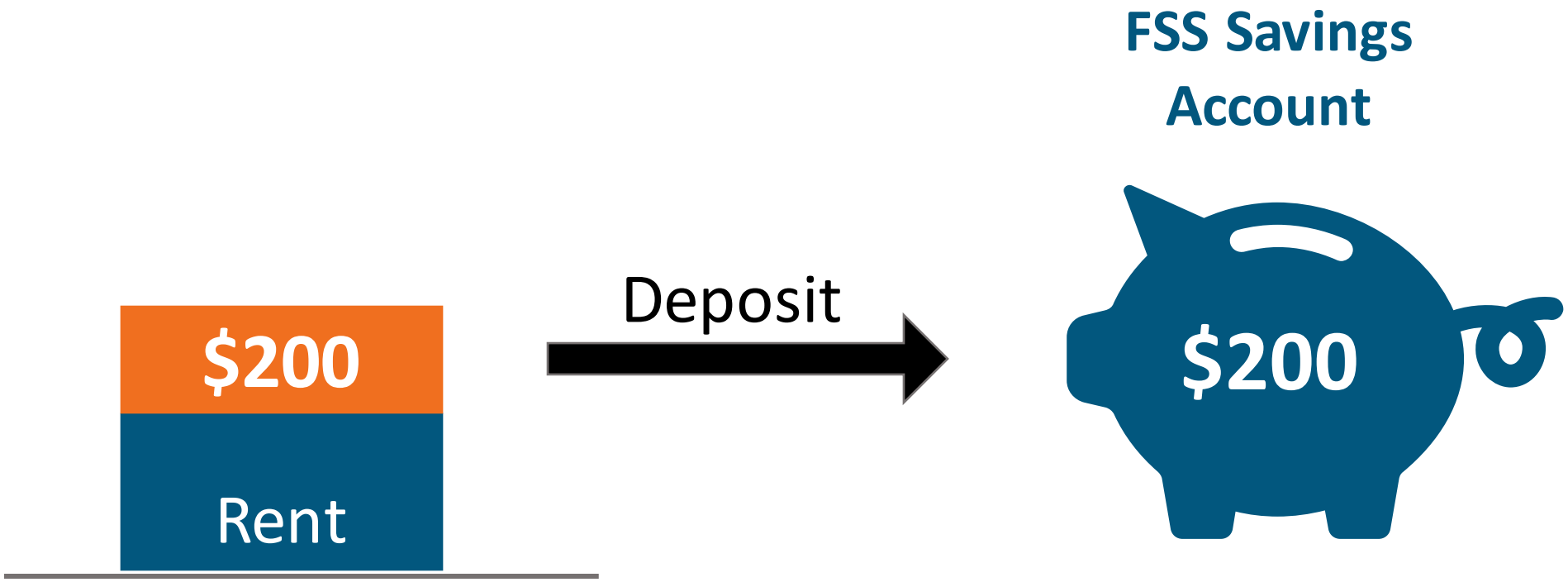
June starts the FSS program making $16,000 a year, paying $400 in rent.



# June gets a promotion at work and her rent increases to $600.



Because June is in the FSS Program, her housing provider will **automatically deposit** $200 into her FSS Savings Account when she pays her rent every month.



After one year of paying $600 in rent every month, June has $2,400 in her account.

**One Year of Deposits**

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| $200 | $200 | $200 | $200 |
| $200 | $200 | $200 | $200 |
| $200 | $200 | $200 | $200 |

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**FSS Savings Account**

# 5 Years of Savings

## FSS Savings Account

June has worked with her financial coach to complete her goals and has fulfilled all the graduation requirements.

She can now graduate and receive her FSS Savings in FULL!

# How it works!

## How do I begin saving?

Everett Housing Authority will begin depositing money into the participant's FSS Savings Account after they report an earned income increase for anyone in the household and begin paying the new rent.

## Does it include all income increases?

No. Deposits into the FSS Savings Account only occur when rent increases due to an earned income increase. Earned income is money received from employment; it does not include child support, social security, cash assistance, or unemployment.

## What if earned income never increases?

Participants will not receive any deposits into the savings account, but they can still benefit from the support they receive from their financial coach. The FSS financial coach can help them identify other savings opportunities and provide financial empowerment tools to help their income go further. However, in order to graduate participants must be employed.

## Do participants have access to the account?

They do not have direct access to the account; they can request money for eligible expenses to help them make progress towards their goals in the program. This is called an interim withdrawal. The request must be approved following EHA's approval guidelines. The FSS financial coach will work with them to facilitate the request.

## What happens when they graduate?

When they successfully complete the program, they will receive a check for the amount in thier FSS Savings Account. These dollars are not taxed or counted in determining benefit eligibility. If they do not meet the program requirements or leave the program by choice, they will forfeit any accumulated savings in the account.

# What is Financial Coaching?

Let's create a plan to reach your goals!

# Financial Coaching is…

## A partnership

The FSS financial coach will be a partner and will provide resources, information, accountability, and support, as well as track progress towards goals to help participants successfully complete the program.

## Judgement Free

FSS coaches provide a judgement-free zone focused on the participant and what they want to accomplish. We believe they are the experts in their own lives.

# What types of things can a Financial Coach help with?

| Financial Opportunities | Lower your Expenses | Credit & Debt | Emergency Savings | Assets | Insurance |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| ☐ Set long-term goals<br>☐ Break your big goal into small steps<br>☐ College savings<br>☐ Homeownership<br>☐ Retirement<br>☐ Open a small business<br>☐ Purchasing or repairing a car<br>☐ Accessing community resources | ☐ Stop unwanted spending<br>☐ Track expenses<br>☐ Negotiate a lower payment<br>☐ Apply for fuel assistance or SNAP benefits<br>☐ Access VITA sites to get taxes done for free | ☐ Get free credit reports with FICO score<br>☐ Pay down credit cards<br>☐ Settle collections<br>☐ Open a secured credit card<br>☐ Learn what can lower your credit score<br>☐ Public Service Loan Forgiveness and Income Driven Repayment plans for student loans | ☐ Open a no-fee checking or savings account<br>☐ Calculate how much you can be savings<br>☐ Set up direct deposit into your savings account<br>☐ If you've had trouble opening a bank account, learn how to clear your ChexSystem report | ☐ Establish a dedicated account for each savings goal<br>☐ Open a retirement account<br>☐ Save for a down payment on a house and access first-time homebuyer programs<br>☐ Open a college savings account<br>☐ Increase retirement plan contributions | ☐ How to plan for a loss of income<br>☐ Research different life insurance policies<br>☐ Learn the difference between term and whole life insurance<br>☐ Renter's insurance<br>☐ Long-term/Short-term disability benefits |

# More Benefits!

## Free Credit Reports

The FSS coach will assist with obtaining credit reports and provide credit-building information.

## Financial Workshops

By attending optional workshops on various topics such as “Navigating the Car-buying Process” and “Budgeting Success” Participants build their self- efficacy.

## Referrals

If we cannot directly assist, we will help participants find the right resources or refer them to organizations that can help in areas such as free tax preparation, car buying, legal services, and small business development.

# How often do you meet?

To graduate from the FSS Program, participants must reach the goals they set for themselves. That is why financial coaching appointments are a requirement for successful completion the program and access their savings.

If they would like more support and need to meet more frequently, they can!

| | Required Appointments | Schedule |
|---|---|---|
| **First Year** | 4 | Intake, 3 month, 6 month, 1 year |
| **2nd Year – Graduation** | 2 | Every 6 months |

They must complete their first financial coaching appointment, also known as a goal setting appointment, within 90 days after signing the contract.

Phone

Online Video Chat

# Appointments are available by:

In Person

# Missed Appointment Policy

We know that sometimes life gets in the way and that participants might not be able to make it to a coaching appointment. **If that is the case, we ask that they reschedule as soon as possible.**

If they do not complete at least one coaching appointment and complete two progress reports over the course of one year, they will be at risk of having your FSS Savings Account closed and forfeit any savings in the account.

# Graduation Requirements

# To graduate the program and receive the savings in full, participants must:

- Be employed
- Meet regularly with the FSS financial coach to complete goals
- Be off cash welfare assistance at the time of graduation (all household members)
- Be in compliance with the lease

# Eligibility and Referral

ELIGIBILITY

1. Be an EHA voucher recipients
2. In good standing with lease
3. Motivated and able to work
4. Participants will be asked to complete a pre-enrollment assessment to ensure that the FSS Program is a good fit.

REFERRAL

1. Community Partners can refer participants by sending a signed ROI, the client's name, phone number and email address to FSS@EHA.org.

# Questions?

# NEXT STEPS

Postcards, Flyers and Business Cards: Distribute freely!

Our Website: www.evha.org/family-self-sufficiency-program

Thank you for inviting me to join you today!